

You shall not pass!



We pit 18 security suites head to head against some of the nastiest malware circulating the globe. Read on to find out which one comes out on top

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Securing your PC from infection has come a really long way from just protecting it from a simple virus or a worm. A simple anti-virus (AV) program is no longer sufficient protection as we have the world's largest virus bank literally at our fingertips, the web. Malware has grown very subtle over the years and (mostly) tries to get into the PC in the form of a trojan (seemingly innocent files), in fact, the most common way for a "virus" to get into a system nowadays is user-error, an accidental click on the wrong link and hey presto, you have given someone a backdoor to your system. It needn't even be accidental, that link or file you clicked or downloaded might seem perfectly innocuous and safe, in fact, most of the time it will do exactly what you wanted it to and the malware will just silently sneak into your system and wreak havoc without you even knowing that something is wrong.

If security is a priority, it has become essential to provide a fully-featured suite that not only detects viruses, but protects your web browsing as well.

In this month's security suite comparison we take a look at 18 security suites and pit them head to head to see how they fare. The test process is laid out on the next page for your perusal. The reason we have not given any specifics regarding the malware and payloads that we used is that these malware are extremely dangerous in the wrong hands and any user, experienced or otherwise, can run into a lot of trouble, or create it for that matter, if you doesn't know what you're is doing.

Features and design

The various security suites in our test were packed to the brim with features like spam and phishing filters, link scanners and virtual keyboards. As a bonus, most of the suites also came with system optimizers and secure file erasers and other miscellaneous utilities. Many of the suites, notably Avast and Bitdefender, came with a browser sandbox mode. This works by isolating the browser entirely from the system, so any malware that you may have

inadvertently triggered will not, in theory, affect your system. Some suites like Avast and NetProtect also came with Windows Gadgets which you could use for quick access to essential aspects of your security.

Avast has an interesting feature where you can configure the system to send you an e-mail or even a printout when malware of any sort is detected. This will probably be useful for system admins as well as power-users who might want to monitor their systems remotely. Bitdefender in particular was the most feature-rich suite of the lot. It includes a lot of options and tweaks and even monitors aspects such as password strength and windows and application updates. Another interesting feature of Bitdefender was the rescue mode that it offered. You can use the program to create a system rescue partition and boot into that using Bitdefender to deal with your system when it is infected.

We noticed a few quirks with some of the programs as well. NetProtect Anti-Virus (NPAV) completely disabled